

Aviation Careers and Pilot Routes

NAME _____ | DATE _____ | PERIOD _____

Read the labels before comparing

All pay figures below are **May 2024 U.S. national medians from BLS**, accessed August 2026. They are not DFW starting pay, entry pay, or a guarantee.

1. Three aviation careers

CAREER	CORE WORK	COMMON PREPARATION	NATIONAL MEDIAN
Commercial pilot	Fly and navigate aircraft; communicate with crews and ATC	FAA flight training and certificates; some employers require or prefer a degree	\$122,670
Air traffic controller	Direct aircraft movement and maintain separation	FAA eligibility, testing, academy training, and facility training	\$144,580
Aircraft mechanic / service technician	Inspect, test, repair, and document aircraft systems	Often an FAA-approved maintenance program; other routes may include military or supervised experience	\$78,680

Career whose daily work interests me most: _____

Why:

Preparation fact that requires the most planning:

One salary-label mistake I must avoid:

2. Civilian pilot preparation example

1. Verify eligibility and medical requirements for the intended certificate or job.
2. Choose an FAA-certificated instructor or school. A Part 141 school uses an FAA-approved structured curriculum; some colleges pair a degree with flight training.
3. Earn required certificates and ratings, build required experience, and complete employer training.
4. Scheduled airline work requires ATP qualifications. A commercial certificate comes earlier and is not the same credential.

Two entry or preparation steps:

1.

2.

One possible advantage supported by the information:

One tradeoff or uncertainty:

Authorized source or person for the next question: _____

Question to verify:

3. Military pilot example: U.S. Air Force

This is one branch-specific example, not a promise or a model for every military aviation job.

- 1. Qualify for an officer route and hold or be near completion of a bachelor's degree.
- 2. Meet academic, testing, selection, medical, physical, security, and age requirements.
- 3. Complete officer and pilot training if selected. Aircraft and location are not guaranteed by preference.
- 4. Current Air Force information states a 10-year active-duty service commitment after pilot training.

Two entry or preparation steps:

- 1.

- 2.

One possible advantage supported by the information:

One tradeoff or uncertainty:

Authorized source or person for the next question: _____

Question to verify:

4. Recommend a first route for fictional Sam

Sam wants to investigate becoming a pilot. Sam needs a route with a clear sequence and wants to understand the commitment before deciding.

First route Sam should investigate: _____

Sentence 1: Name the route and one entry step.

Sentence 2: Explain one tradeoff or uncertainty.

Sentence 3: Name the source or authorized person Sam should use next and why.

5. Local boundary

Current Irving ISD public information lists Aviation Maintenance, Drone Engineering, and Marine JROTC at Irving High School. JROTC teaches citizenship, leadership, and responsibility; it is not pilot training and does not guarantee military aviation selection.

One course access or pathway detail I need a current coursebook or counselor to verify:

Sources

FAA aviation careers, pilot schools, and ATC qualifications; BLS occupational profiles; U.S. Air Force pilot career page; Irving ISD CTE page. Accessed August 2026.